Replied the Angel. Abou spoke more low,

But cheerly still; and said, "I pray thee, then,

Write me as one that loves his fellow men."

The angel wrote, and vanished. The next night

It came again with a great wakening light,

And showed the names whom love of God had blessed,

And lot Ben Adhem s name led all the rest.

It seems to me that no one who had studied the psychology of English teachers (and their pupils must do so if they are to survive) could fail to see what the first question would be. I didn't fail to see it, and I was prepared.

Our teacher said, "Now, class, why did Abou Ben Adhem's name lead all the rest?"

My hand shot up. He said, "Yes, Asimov?"

And I said, with a polite note of uncertainty, "Alphabetical order, sir?"

The class roared and I placed an astonished look on my face, and the teacher lifted his arm and pointed to the door.

I got up. "But what else could it be, sir?"

"Just report to the principal's office," he said.

Oh well.

None of this ever hurt me scholastically, though it may possibly have contributed to my not making Arista.

What did hurt me scholastically was a particularly unpleasant discovery I made in high school. Until then, all scholastic subjects had been the same. Whatever schoolbook we opened—history, geography, arithmetic, grammar—it was all interesting, it was all fun, and, most of all, it was all easy.

I suppose I could be excused for thinking that this was a universal law of nature. Then, in high school, I found that one of my classes was